

FREE GUIDE · UPDATED OCT 2026 · 4 BASES

PCS GUIDE TO THE MIDLANDS

Fort Jackson, Shaw, McEntire and Parris Island. Housing links, drive times and a first-30-days checklist. Tap any button and your phone takes you straight there.



SCOTT DAVIS
Palmetto Park Team at LPT Realty · @normanjtheagent

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

CONTENTS

Tap any line to jump to it. On every page, buttons open the base's official site, its housing office or Google Maps. **Back to contents** at the bottom of each page brings you here.

BASES

03 Fort Jackson — Columbia

04 Fort Jackson commute guide — Lexington, Irmo, downtown, Blythewood

05 Shaw Air Force Base — Sumter

06 McEntire Joint National Guard Base — Eastover

07 Marine Corps Recruit Depot Parris Island — Beaufort area

PLAN THE MOVE

08 Housing and money — BAH, VA loan, Plan My Move

09 Your first 30 days — Checklist

10 Family and spouse resources — Schools, jobs, support

START HERE

11 Talk to a realtor who has done this — Free, no pressure

Facts come from each base's official website and Military OneSource, checked Oct 22, 2026. Policies, hours and rates change. Tap the official link and confirm before you act.

COLUMBIA, SC · U.S. ARMY

FORT JACKSON

VICTORY STARTS HERE

Fort Jackson is an Army training installation in Columbia. Basic Combat Training runs here, and the Soldier Support Institute and Drill Sergeant Academy are on post.

MAIN UNITS AND TENANTS

- 165th Infantry Brigade
- 193rd Infantry Brigade
- Soldier Support Institute
- U.S. Army Drill Sergeant Academy
- Army Chaplain Center and School
- National Center for Credibility Assessment
- Medical Department Activity (MEDDAC)

HOUSING OFFICE

- Housing Services Office, 4514 8th Div Rd, Fort Jackson, SC 29207
- Visit the housing office before you sign a lease or contract.
- Gate and visitor access rules change. Check the access control page before you drive in.

DRIVE TIMES (TYPICAL, OFF-PEAK) · TAP A ROW FOR LIVE DIRECTIONS

Fort Jackson to downtown Columbia — **15 to 20 min**

Typical, off-peak

Official site | Housing office | Newcomers | Gate info | Units | Map

Motto from the Fort Jackson official site. Unit list from the base units page and Fort Jackson history page. Next: the commute guide on page 4.

FORT JACKSON

COMMUTE GUIDE

Where you live decides your daily drive. These are the four areas most Fort Jackson families ask about. Times are typical drives from the post to the town center, off-peak. Add 10 to 20 minutes at rush hour. Tap a row to open live directions in Google Maps.

Fort Jackson to Lexington
Downtown Lexington · via I-26 or US-378

30 to 40 min

Fort Jackson to Irmo
Town center · via I-77 and I-26

30 to 40 min

Fort Jackson to downtown Columbia
The Vista and Main Street

15 to 20 min

Fort Jackson to Blythewood
Town center · via I-77 north

20 to 30 min

How I would choose. Pick the commute first. Drive the route at the hour you will really drive it, before you pick a house. A house 10 minutes closer each way saves about 80 hours a year, based on 250 workdays.

CLOSER TO POST

- Downtown Columbia and the Vista
- Northeast Columbia and Blythewood
- Short drive, more city, smaller lots

MORE SPACE

- Lexington and Irmo
- Lake Murray and good schools
- Longer drive, more house for the money

Times are typical estimates, not guarantees. Traffic, construction, gate wait times and the exact address change them. Always check the live route before you sign.

SUMTER, SC · U.S. AIR FORCE

SHAW AIR FORCE BASE

HOME OF THE 20TH FIGHTER WING

Shaw is home to the 20th Fighter Wing, which flies the F-16 Fighting Falcon and is known for its Wild Weasel mission. It also hosts Ninth Air Force (Air Forces Central) and U.S. Army Central (Third Army). Many Shaw families live in Sumter.

MAIN UNITS

- 20th Fighter Wing (F-16 Fighting Falcon)
- Ninth Air Force (Air Forces Central)
- U.S. Army Central (Third Army)
- Full unit list on Military OneSource

HOUSING

- Military Housing Office, 369 Rhodes Ave, Shaw AFB, SC 29152
- Privatized housing on base through Hunt Military Communities (Shaw Family Housing)
- Contact housing as soon as you have orders

DRIVE TIMES (TYPICAL, OFF-PEAK) · TAP A ROW FOR LIVE DIRECTIONS

Shaw to Sumter
Downtown Sumter
10 to 15 min

Shaw to Columbia
Downtown Columbia · via US-378
45 to 55 min

Official site | Housing | Shaw Family Housing | Check-in | Major units | Map

Shaw does not state a motto on its official site, so this page uses its official "home of" line. Unit names from the Shaw official site and Military OneSource.

EASTOVER, SC · SC AIR NATIONAL GUARD

MCENTIRE JOINT NATIONAL GUARD BASE

HOME OF THE 169TH FIGHTER WING

McEntire is the home of the South Carolina Air National Guard's 169th Fighter Wing, which flies the F-16 Fighting Falcon. Guard families often live in Columbia, Eastover and the Lower Richland area.

MAIN UNIT

- 169th Fighter Wing, South Carolina Air National Guard
- F-16 Fighting Falcon
- 1325 South Carolina Rd, Eastover, SC 29044

BEFORE YOU BUY

- Ask your unit about drill schedule and duty days before you pick an area.
- Check Military OneSource for base services that apply to Guard members.

DRIVE TIMES (TYPICAL, OFF-PEAK) · TAP A ROW FOR LIVE DIRECTIONS

McEntire to downtown Columbia
Typical, off-peak

30 to 40 min

Official site | Military OneSource page | Map

McEntire does not state a motto on its official site, so this page uses its official "home of" line.

BEAUFORT AREA, SC · U.S. MARINE CORPS

PARRIS ISLAND

WE MAKE MARINES

Marine Corps Recruit Depot Parris Island trains new Marines. It is on the coast near Beaufort and Port Royal, about two hours from Columbia. Many families here live on base, in Port Royal or in Beaufort.

MAIN UNITS

- Recruit Training Regiment
- 1st, 2nd and 3rd Recruit Training Battalions
- Support Battalion and Drill Instructor School
- Weapons and Field Training Battalion
- Headquarters and Service Battalion
- Eastern Recruiting Region

HOUSING AND VISITORS

- Housing Office, 402 Blvd de France, Parris Island, SC 29905
- Visiting a recruit? Graduation schedule and visitor base access are on the official site.

DRIVE TIMES (TYPICAL, OFF-PEAK) · TAP A ROW FOR LIVE DIRECTIONS

Parris Island to Beaufort — 15 to 25 min
Typical, off-peak

Parris Island to downtown Columbia — about 2 hr 15 min
Not a daily commute

Official site | Visitors | Graduation schedule | Housing | Map

"We Make Marines" is the depot mission line on its official site (the site does not list a separate motto). Unit list from the official site.

PLAN THE MOVE

HOUSING AND MONEY

Three decisions drive a PCS housing choice: what BAH covers, whether to rent or buy, and how the commute fits your daily life. Start with the official tools below.

BAH

- Basic Allowance for Housing depends on your rank, dependents and duty location.
- Use the official DTMO calculator. Look up the rate for your base ZIP, not a number from a friend.
- Rates reset each January. Check the year you move.

VA LOAN

- Many VA loans need no down payment and no monthly mortgage insurance.
- You need your Certificate of Eligibility. Your lender can pull it.
- Compare lenders. Rates and fees differ.

RENT OR BUY

- Short tour or unsure of your next orders? Renting is easier to exit.
- Staying 3 or more years? Buying can build equity and can rent out later.
- Ask about your lease military clause before you sign.

MOVE LOGISTICS

- Plan My Move builds a checklist from your orders.
- Vehicle registration: active-duty rules are on the SCDMV military page.
- Keep copies of your orders and ID on your phone.

BAH calculator | VA home loans | Plan My Move | SC DMV military | MilitaryINSTALLATIONS

Not financial or legal advice. I am a realtor, not a lender or attorney. Use the official tools, and talk to a VA-experienced lender before you make an offer.

PLAN THE MOVE

YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

A simple order to work in. Print it or screenshot it.

BEFORE YOU ARRIVE

- ☐ Get your orders and report date in writing
- ☐ Contact your sponsor
- ☐ Look up BAH for your base ZIP
- ☐ Contact the base housing office
- ☐ Pick your commute and drive it on a map first
- ☐ Start school records and medical records transfers

WEEK 1

- ☐ Check in with your unit and housing office
- ☐ Update ID and DEERS for the family
- ☐ Set up utilities and internet
- ☐ Register your vehicle (active-duty rules apply)
- ☐ Find the commissary, clinic and child care
- ☐ Enroll kids in school

WEEKS 2 TO 4

- ☐ Decide rent or buy with real numbers
- ☐ Get a pre-approval if you are buying
- ☐ Tour homes in person or by live video
- ☐ Meet neighbors and find your gym and church
- ☐ Save your receipts for moving reimbursement

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- ☐ How long is my commute at rush hour?
- ☐ Which gate will I use and how long is the wait?
- ☐ Is the lease military clause in writing?
- ☐ Which school zone is this address in?

Plan My Move | Fort Jackson newcomers | Shaw check-in

Rules differ by branch, base and orders. This is a general checklist, not official guidance.

PLAN THE MOVE

FAMILY AND SPOUSE

A PCS is a family move. These official programs help with jobs, school, child care and special needs.

SPOUSE CAREERS

- SpouseWorks has career tools and job help.
- MyCAA offers education funding for eligible spouses.
- Military and family support centers help with local jobs.

KIDS AND SCHOOLS

- Ask the base for the school zone map before you pick a house.
- Shaw posts local schools and child care on Military OneSource.
- Start records transfers before you arrive.

SPECIAL NEEDS

- Exceptional Family Member Program (EFMP) supports families with special medical or education needs.
- Tell your housing and relocation office early.

PETS

- Check base and lease pet policies before you sign.
- Plan vet records and any shipping needs early.

SpouseWorks | MyCAA | EFMP and Me | Shaw local schools | Shaw child care | Shaw relocation help

Links go to official Military OneSource and base pages. Programs and eligibility change. Confirm on the official page.

START HERE

TALK TO A REALTOR WHO HAS DONE THIS

I was born and raised in Lexington. I am a Military Relocation Professional (MRP), and I help military families pick the right area, the right commute and the right loan. No pressure. Tell me your base and your report date, and I will send you options.

Start here: 2-minute form



SCOTT DAVIS

Palmetto Park Team at LPT Realty
MRP · @normanjtheagent

PALMETTO PARK REALTY TEAM · lpt · MRP · REALTOR · EQUAL HOUSING OPPORTUNITY

This guide is not affiliated with or endorsed by the Department of Defense, the Army, the Air Force, the Marine Corps, any base or any government agency. Base names, mottos and unit names come from official public websites as of Oct 22, 2026. Drive times are typical estimates, not guarantees. This guide is not legal, tax or financial advice. Equal Housing Opportunity.